

The Magic is Still On

BSP's win in all five by-elections bolsters Mayawati's ambition

It is a fitting rebuke to her critics. By winning all the five recent by-elections in her state—two Lok Sabha and three Assembly seats, Mayawati has pulled off another coup. This despite the fact that all her rivals—BJP, the Congress and the Samajwadi Party (SP) had made her the prime target of their attack. The Congress and BJP lost their deposits in four places, while SP lost in one. More to the point, BSP's victory has proved that despite nearly one year in office, anti-incumbency has not set in. BSP's defeat to SP in the Balia Lok Sabha bypoll in December last year had emboldened the Opposition. Now a triumphant Mayawati has shot back, "This election makes it clear that BSP is all set for a big game in the next Lok Sabha elections."

BSP candidates Akbar Ahmed Dumpy and Bhishm Shankar Tewari won the by-elections in Azamgarh and Khalilabad, respectively, by defeating their nearest rivals—and former BSP MPs—Rama Kant Yadav of BJP and Bhal Chand Yadav of SP. The two Lok Sabha by-elections had to be conducted because both the defeated candidates had switched sides, leaving BSP before the 2007 Assembly elections. This has cost them dearly. As for the Assembly seats, BSP candidates Rajni



SIPRA DAS

CIRCLE OF POWER: Despite the best efforts of a united Opposition, Mayawati's votebank is intact

Tewari, Rajpal Tyagi and Brij Singh won from Bilgram in Hardoi, Moradnagar in Ghaziabad and Colonelganj in Gonda.

It was a high-profile onslaught by the Opposition. While BJP chief Rajnath Singh campaigned extensively for his candidates, SP chief Mulayam Singh Yadav provoked 22,000 dismissed constables to take to the streets and supported students in opposing the ban on students' union polls. The Congress charge was led by its posterboy and heir apparent Rahul Gandhi himself, who even spent a night out at a Dalit's house in a blatant attempt to win the backward vote back from BSP. Mayawati scoffs, saying, "This by-election exposes the Congress drama of wooing the Dalits." What did not help her rivals either was that they supported Bharatiya Kisan Union chief Mahendra Singh Tikait, who hurled derogatory, casteist remarks at her.

Clearly, neither the Congress nor BJP has anything to offer the upper castes, who were wooed successfully by BSP in the 2007 state polls. With Mayawati retaining her hold in Uttar Pradesh and making her presence felt both in the neighbouring north and even in the south—BSP is planning to contest the Karnataka state polls—it looks as if her war cry of "*UP hui hamaari hai, ab Dilli ki baari hai*" (UP is ours, Delhi is next), may well come true.

by Subhash Mishra

the leader of the Government, have been taken away by the Gandhi family. The Right to Information Bill is credited to Sonia's National Advisory Council, while the extension of the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme (NREGS)—something that was already on the cards before Rahul pressed for it—has been ascribed to the heir apparent. The credit for the farmers' loan waiver, too, went to 10 Janpath even before it was announced in the Budget.

Crucial decisions are not taken by the UPA Cabinet presided over by the prime minister, but by the core committee under Sonia's leadership. A petrol price hike awaits her nod before it is passed by the Cabinet, and a plea by Minister for Commerce Kamal Nath directly to Sonia can postpone a key Cabinet meeting on steel and iron ore prices. The leader of the Opposition has already called him "India's weakest prime minister". Admits L.K. Advani, "My words hurt the prime minister, but under him the Prime Minister's Office has shifted to 10 Janpath."

If Sonia had wanted to ratify Manmohan's leadership credentials, she could easily have asked him to contest an election. For now, the Gandhis have made it clear that there is no vacancy for the top job. Manmohan knows he is merely keeping the seat warm for the crown prince. This is one reason why he offered Rahul a ringside view of South Block as minister of state in the PMO in the last reshuffle. But like his father, Rahul said he first wanted to concentrate on the organisation before taking on ministerial chores. The correct footnote here would be to add that Rajiv Gandhi was propelled from being general secretary to prime minister without serving as a minister of state.

The 80-year-old Advani, too, knows that in his race for prime ministership, he would not be competing as much against Manmohan's credentials as against Rahul's youthful charm. At the launch of a website for his autobiography, Advani spoke of the need to use high-tech tools to woo the youth. What he left unsaid was that this is exactly what Rahul has been doing with his interactive website and online membership drive.

With 62 per cent of India below 42 years of age, Rahul is the natural youth icon and the leader of the future. Few